

TECHNOLOGY IN LEGAL PRACTICE:

Leading the Innovation and Digital Transformation
of Justice in Nigeria

Introduction

Permit me to delve straight into the topic for discussion in this session. It is about Innovation in Legal Practice, with particular emphasis on Technology. I am sure you will agree with me that the issue of Justice is a National Emergency, not just in Nigeria, but in all countries around the globe. As we all know, it is the thread that holds the fabric of the society together. If justice breaks down, then the whole society collapses.

Your elevation, therefore, is an ordination into a higher calling of service. And the most urgent call of our time is the imperative to guide the legal profession from its cherished analogue traditions into a more efficient, accessible, and globally competitive digital future. This is the new burden of leadership that your rank confers upon you.

Our Current Reality: A Bridge Half-Built

We have begun the journey of technological adoption. E-filing, virtual proceedings, and digital case management are no longer foreign concepts. The ACJA 2015 provided statutory backbone, and during lockdown, our judiciary demonstrated remarkable adaptability.

Yet we stand on a bridge half-built. The pace remains uneven, with registries buried under paper files whilst others embrace digital portals.



Trends in Legal Technology



Across the world, legal systems are leveraging technology to overcome systemic bottlenecks, enhance service delivery, and align with the expectations of a digitally-native clientele. The trends are clear and their outcomes are measurable. These include, but not limited to the following:



Global Legal Technology Revolution



AI & Machine Learning

Transforming legal research, contract analysis, and document review with unprecedented speed and accuracy.



Digital Case Management

Electronic filing systems creating transparent, auditable trails whilst reducing administrative overhead.



Global Legal Technology Revolution



Virtual Hearings

Court automation enabling remote proceedings, eliminating travel delays and scheduling conflicts.



Blockchain & Smart Contracts

Creating immutable legal records and automating contractual execution in conveyancing and capital markets.

Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning

AI and ML empower computers to perform complex tasks traditionally requiring human intelligence. In the legal sector, these technologies act as sophisticated tools, significantly enhancing various professional tasks:



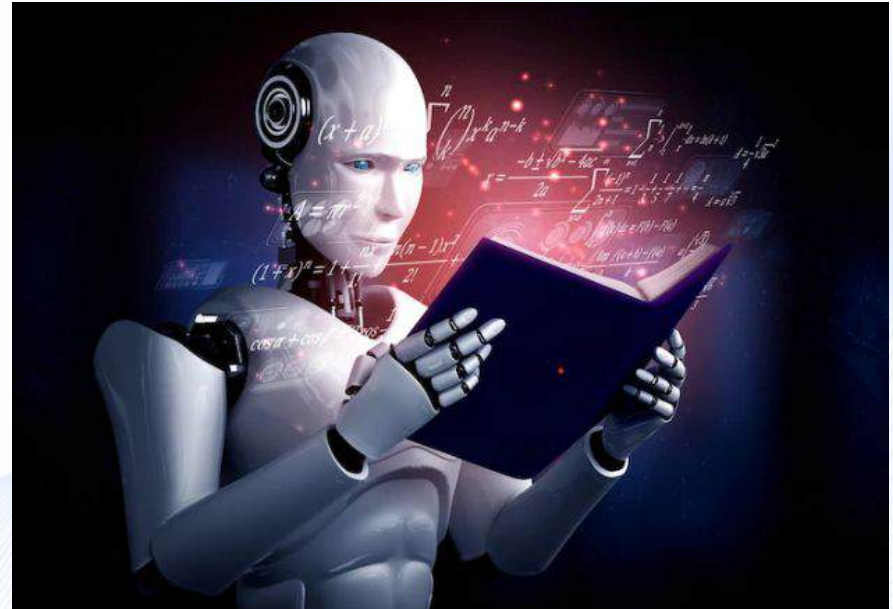
Legal Research

AI, with Natural Language Processing (NLP), enables lawyers to conduct complex research using conversational queries, rapidly retrieving precedents



Document Review & E-Discovery

AI-powered platforms can review millions of documents in minutes, a task that would consume thousands of hours for human legal professionals.



Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning



Contract Analysis & Due Diligence

AI reviews and analyses contracts, pinpointing non-standard clauses, identifying risks, and ensuring regulatory compliance, accelerating due diligence processes.



Predictive Analytics

AI analyses historical case data to forecast potential case outcomes, inform settlement strategies, and estimate litigation costs effectively.

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Five High-Impact Tech Solutions That Can Accelerate The Justice System In Nigeria

Without a doubt, The Nigerian Justice System needs some **VERY BOLD INTERVENTIONS** driven by Technology. Bringing it home, let's examine some of the practical high-impactful tech solutions that can accelerate the justice delivery in Nigeria.



Five High-Impact Tech Solutions for Nigerian Justice

AI Judgment Conflict Checker

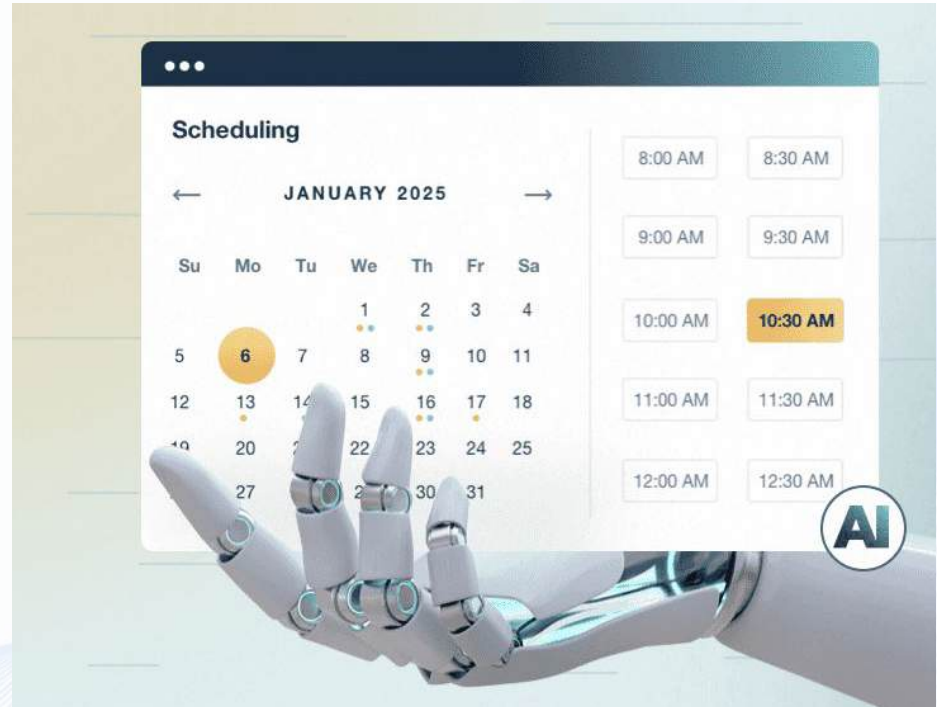
Central repository testing new judgments against existing ones, preventing conflicting decisions using NLP technology.



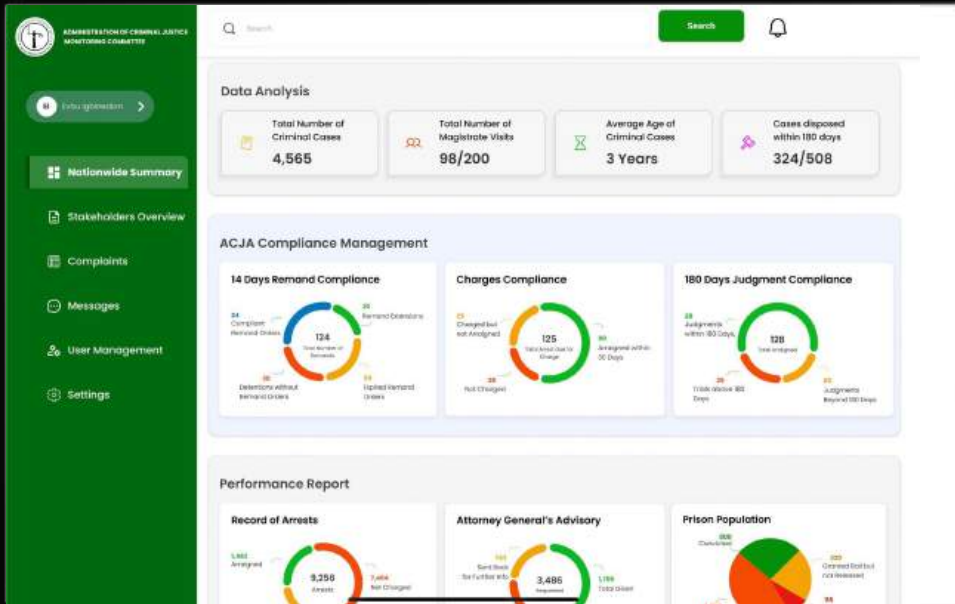
Five High-Impact Tech Solutions for Nigerian Justice

Docket Scheduling System

Specific time allocation instead of blanket "9 a.m." listings, with automatic notifications for schedule changes.



Five High-Impact Tech Solutions for Nigerian Justice



ACJMC Monitoring Portal

Integrated platform for criminal justice stakeholders ensuring ACJA compliance and real-time case monitoring.

Five High-Impact Tech Solutions for Nigerian Justice



04

AI Speech-to-Text Transcription

Localized solution trained with Nigerian voices, working offline, providing real-time court proceeding transcripts.



05

Justice Clock Dashboard

Public-facing platform displaying average case age across all court tiers, enabling performance evaluation and accountability.

The Justice Clock: A Paradigm Shift

"You cannot manage what you don't measure." — Peter Drucker

Justice Clock is a national dashboard tracking case age across all judiciary tiers, replacing subjective evaluation with objective data. Here is why this single act of measurement is critical for comprehensive reform:

1. Enabling Effective Performance Evaluation: For too long, the evaluation of judicial performance has been subjective. The Justice Clock replaces ambiguity with objective data. With clear metrics on the age of cases, judicial leadership can:

Identify Bottlenecks

Empirical evidence pinpoints delays in specific courts, states, or case types for targeted interventions.

Establish Benchmarks

Set realistic, measurable performance goals creating standards for excellence nationwide.

Promote Accountability

Visible performance metrics foster responsibility among stakeholders and enable effective management.

2. Building a Compelling Case for Higher Judicial Funding



From Anecdote to Evidence

Instead of general statements about being "underfunded," the judiciary can present clear data showing, for example, that a 20% increase in case backlogs in a specific jurisdiction correlates with a lack of judges or inadequate court infrastructure.



Strategic Resource Allocation

This data justifies not just more funding, but smarter funding. It can pinpoint exactly where investment is needed most urgently—be it in technology, personnel, or training—to have the greatest impact on reducing case delays.



Ease of Doing Business Ranking

The showcase of National ranking of State High Courts on the Average Age of Case scale among other States throws up the relevance of Justice to ease of doing business, making speed of justice delivery a political point for evaluation of State Governments.

3. Rebuilding Public Trust and Improving Perception



Embracing Transparency

Making case age data public is a radical act of transparency.



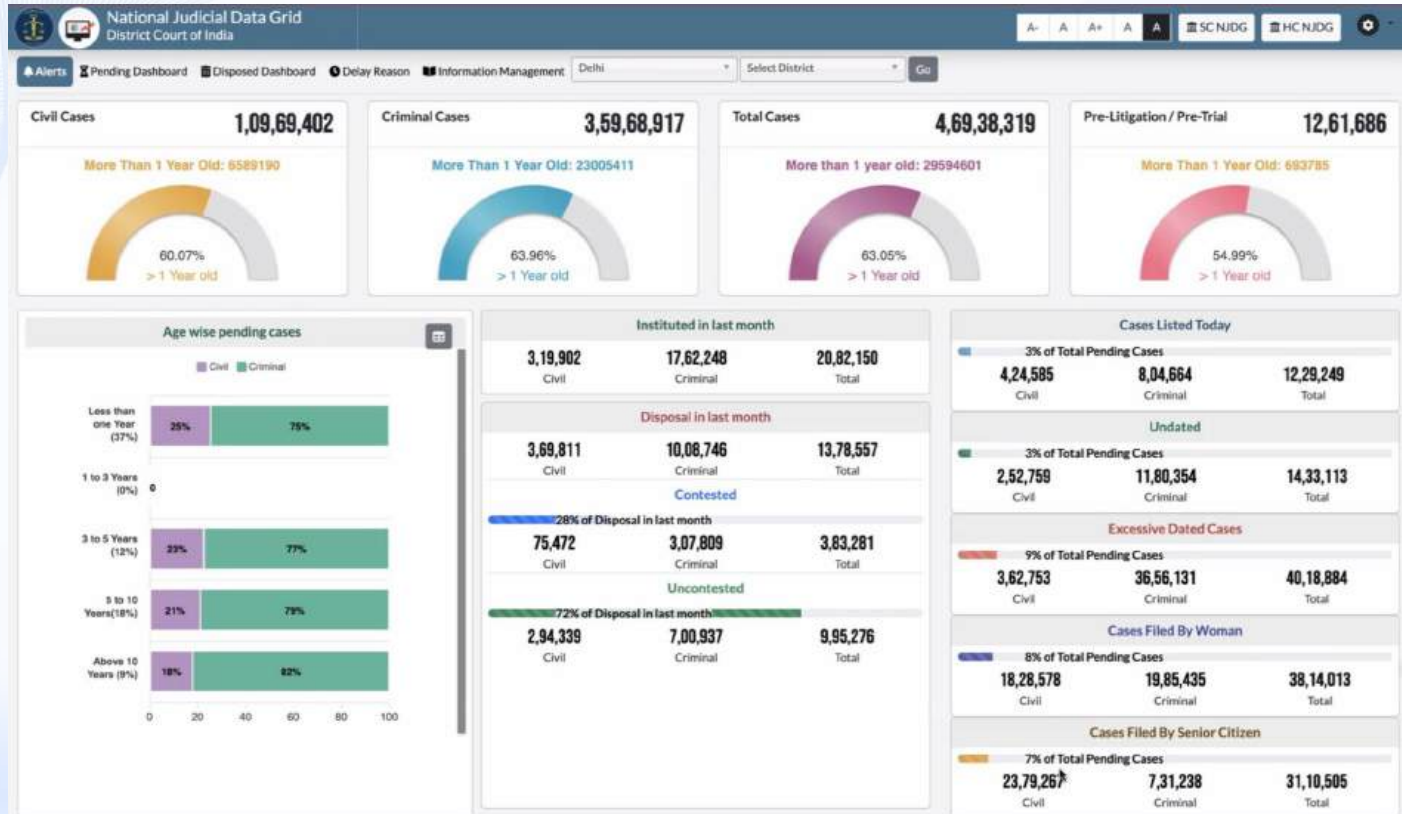
Demonstrating a Commitment to Reform

This initiative shows that the judiciary is a forward-thinking institution committed to modernization and accountability. This proactive stance can significantly improve public confidence, reassuring citizens, investors, and international partners that Nigeria is serious about the rule of law.

"Justice delayed is justice denied" - The Justice Clock directly confronts this powerful public sentiment.

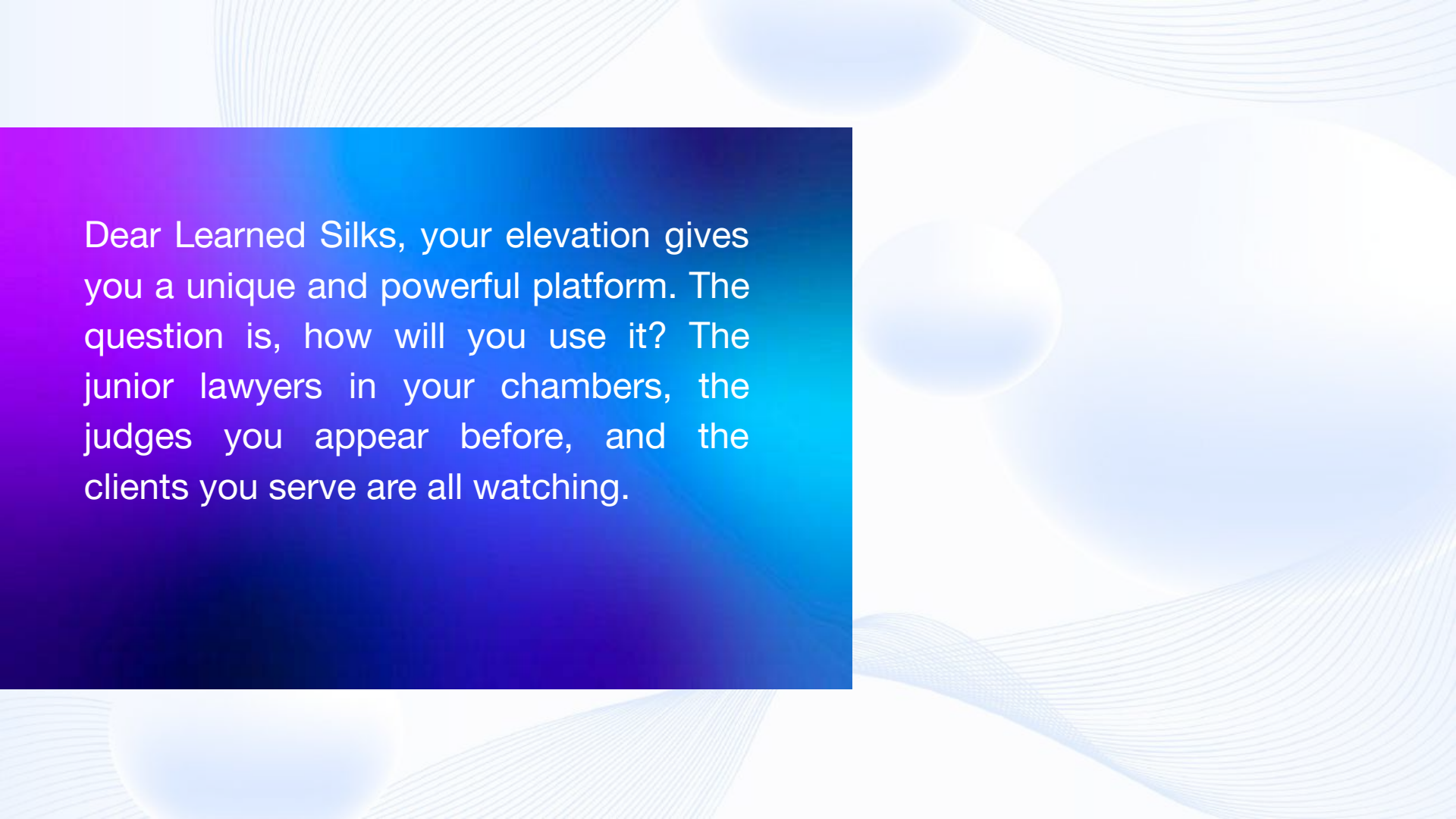


Rwanda has long gone ahead with this. Incidentally, I just got to find out, last Friday, that this is now also already implemented in India. Please see the picture below.



The background is a vibrant blue with a gradient from deep navy to a lighter cyan. It features a series of concentric, wavy lines that create a sense of depth and movement, resembling a stylized ocean or a digital wave pattern. A bright, glowing light source is visible in the upper right quadrant, casting a soft, ethereal glow across the scene.

**Why Are We Having This
Conversation?**



Dear Learned Silks, your elevation gives you a unique and powerful platform. The question is, how will you use it? The junior lawyers in your chambers, the judges you appear before, and the clients you serve are all watching.

Why Are We Having This Conversation?



Role Model

Lead by personal example.

Master new tools, file electronically, and demonstrate that technological proficiency is the new standard of excellence.



Why Are We Having This Conversation?



Leader

Use your influence in the Body of Benchers and NBA to advocate system-wide change. Move from piecemeal adoption to unified national policy.

Why Are We Having This Conversation?



Coach

Become your chambers' Chief Innovation Officer. Train juniors in e-discovery alongside cross-examination. Build a practice sustainable for the next century.



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Navigating Nigeria's Legal and Regulatory Framework for Technology in Legal Practice

Nigeria's Evolving Digital Legal Framework



The Nigerian legal landscape is undergoing a significant digital transformation. What began as a nascent effort to digitize court records has evolved into a complex web of statutes, rules, and policies governing everything from electronic evidence to virtual court proceedings. Below is an overview of this evolving framework, key provisions and practical implications for practitioners.

Nigeria's Evolving Digital Legal Framework

Federal Laws: The Foundation of Digital Justice



ACJA 2015: Advancing Judicial Efficiency

The Administration of Criminal Justice Act 2015 introduced provisions to speed up trials and ensure timely justice, laying groundwork for future digital integrations.



Evidence Act Amendment 2023

This pivotal amendment modernises legal proceedings by formally recognising electronic evidence and digital processes in the justice system.

Key Provisions of the Evidence Act Amendment 2023

Sections 84A-84D: Electronic Records

Expanded "admissible documents" to include electronic records and updated methods for validating digital signatures and electronic records.

1

Section 255(2): Electronic Gazette

Defines "official gazette in electronic form", signalling acceptance of online publication of laws as equivalent to Federal Government Gazette.

3

2

Section 108: Electronic Oath Taking

Allows for electronic oath taking through audio-visual means and filing of affidavits electronically, revolutionising court procedures

4

Section 258: Digital Definitions

Defined key terms including "Electronic Records", "digital signatures", and "audio-visual communication" amongst others.

Rules of Court and Practice Directions: Implementing the Framework

While federal statutes provide the legal basis, it is the various court rules and practice directions that give practical effect to technology in litigation. Below are some of such major Rules:

- **The Supreme Court of Nigeria Rules, 2024:** The new Supreme Court Rules, 2024, have introduced novel provisions to ease the tedium of practice before the apex court. Order 3 Rule 1 of the new rules define "address for service" to include "electronic mail address, a GSM telephone number or any other available mode of communication". This expansion allows for the use of modern telecommunication methods like email and WhatsApp for service, ensuring a near-instantaneous process.

Order 3 Rule 2 explicitly states that a notice of appeal shall be served on the respondent(s) either personally, on their legal practitioner who represented them at the Court of Appeal, or through electronic mail or other electronic means. Order 2 Rules 6 & 7 which mandates the Registrar of the Supreme Court to keep appeal books in physical and electronic forms.

The contents of records of appeal have now been extended by Order 6 Rule 2 of the 2024 Rules to include electronic copies of the relevant documents and processes. Order 17 outlines the procedures for filing court processes through the NCMS Efiling portal and Order 18 formally introduces and permits virtual hearings, allowing the Court to conduct proceedings virtually on its own initiative or upon a party's application.

Rules of Court and Practice Directions: Implementing the Framework

- **Court of Appeal Rules, 2021:** The Court of Appeal Rules, 2021, have also embraced technology. Order 1 Rule 5 defines 'Court sittings' to include both physical and virtual sittings of the court. Order 2 Rule 1 allows for notices of Appeal to be served either personally or by electronic mail. Order 8 Rules 3 and 4 permit the Registrar of the lower court or the Appellant, to compile, encrypt and electronically transmit Records of Appeal to the court through the electronic mail address of the registry. Order 20 mandates the establishment of a 24-hour electronic filing system in all divisions of the court, while Order 21 allows for virtual hearings.

Rules of Court and Practice Directions: Implementing the Framework

- **FCT High Court Rules, 2025:** The High Court of the Federal Capital Territory (FCT) Civil Procedure Rules, 2025, have made significant strides, replacing the 2018 Rules. Order 3 rules 5 and 6 of the new Rules gives litigants an option of filing suits either electronically and may continue in the same manner until determination of the matter, while Order 3 rule 9 recognizes electronic signature of court processes. Order 3, part II Rules 1 and 2 made provisions for virtual hearing. Order 9 rule 17 also broadened the means of serving hearing notices to include platforms like WhatsApp and Telegram and/or other electronic means.

Rules of Court and Practice Directions: Implementing the Framework

- **Lagos State High Court (Civil Procedure) Rules, 2019:** Lagos State Judiciary Information System (JIS) facilitates e-filing, allowing practitioners to file cases from anywhere in the world. Lagos High Court Civil Procedure Rules (2019) recognizes email service (Order 33) and extended deadlines, and during COVID the Chief Judge issued a Remote Hearing Practice Direction under Art. 6(6) of the Constitution and court law.

The background is a deep blue gradient with intricate, wavy, concentric line patterns that create a sense of depth and movement. A bright, glowing light source is positioned on the right side, casting a soft, ethereal glow across the scene and highlighting the curves of the background patterns.

Infrastructural Challenges and Regulatory Gaps

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Infrastructure Investments & Access Support:

Rules permitting e-filings or virtual hearings are only as good as the infrastructure that supports them. Too many courts, especially in rural or under-resourced areas, struggle with fundamental challenges that undermine technological progress. SANs can amplify calls for targeted investment in justice infrastructure, ensuring equitable access for all, not just well-resourced jurisdictions.

Monitoring, Review & Iteration of Technology Policies:

Technology evolves faster than the law. Without ongoing review and iteration, even well-intentioned policies risk becoming obsolete or producing unintended consequences such as bias, exclusion, or security vulnerabilities. SANs should take the lead in establishing a culture of continuous policy review, ensuring technology in justice delivery remains relevant, fair, and effective

Monitoring, Review & Iteration of Technology Policies

Developed climates are moving away from a one-size-fits-all approach. For instance, the EU AI Act categorizes AI systems into risk categories, imposing strict requirements on "high-risk" applications like those used in medical devices for diagnosis or surgery. This contrasts with a "low-risk" tool used for medical training or administrative tasks.

In law, this principle could be adapted to require legal tech providers to prove their AI systems are free of bias or error that could lead to malpractice, while maintaining a standard of human oversight, as AI is meant to support, not replace, professional judgment. Ultimately, a balanced approach ensures that innovation continues while human rights, safety, and accountability remain paramount.

The background is a vibrant blue gradient. On the right side, there is a bright, glowing light source that creates a series of concentric, wavy lines radiating outwards. These lines are more pronounced in the upper right and fade towards the left. The overall effect is a sense of depth and movement, with the light source appearing to be behind a translucent, wavy surface.

Conclusion

Dear Learned Silks, the future is not something that merely happens to us; it is something we must build. As was said, the silk gown is heavy, not because of the fabric, but because of the weight of the expectations vested in you. Let us be the generation of leaders who completed the bridge. Let us be the ones who finally traded the pen for the keyboard, the dusty file for the secure cloud, and delay for dispatch.

Let us build a legal system that is not only steeped in the rich tradition of justice but is also powered by the relentless engine of innovation. The digital gavel is in our hands. Let us wield it with the wisdom, integrity, and foresight that our rank demands.

Once again, congratulations on this laudable achievement. Now, let us get to work.

Thank you for having me.

The background is a vibrant blue with a series of concentric, wavy lines that create a sense of depth and movement. The lines are more pronounced in the upper right and lower left areas, while the center is a smoother, darker blue.

Thank you